Modals of obligation and advice: must, should, have to

Goal: To use must, have to and should to express obligation, necessity, prohibition and advice, and to choose the right modal when writing rules and recommendations to protect nature.

The idea in two lines: Must and have to say that something is necessary; should says that something is a good idea. Their negatives do not behave the same way: mustn't forbids, don't have to means "not necessary".

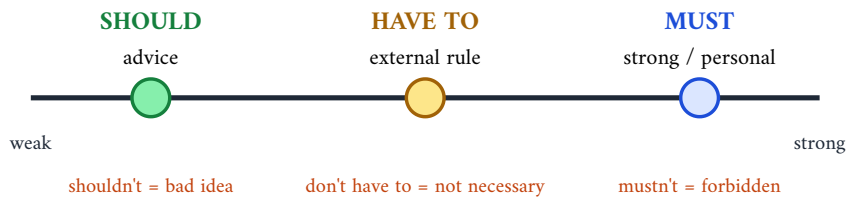


Figure 1: The three modals on a scale of strength, with the meaning of each negative form.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Modal verbs** are followed by the base verb without "to" (must go, should recycle). Have to is a semi-modal: it takes "to" and changes with the subject (he has to).
2. **Must** expresses a strong obligation, often coming from the speaker: "We must protect endangered species."
3. **Have to** expresses an obligation coming from outside: a law, a timetable, a rule. "Visitors have to keep the park clean."
4. **Should** (and ought to) gives advice or a recommendation; it is weaker than must: "You should turn off the lights when you leave."
5. **Mustn't** = prohibition: "You mustn't light fires in the forest." **Don't have to** = absence of obligation: "You don't have to pay to enter the reserve."
6. **Shouldn't** = negative advice: "People shouldn't throw rubbish into the sea."

7. **Past and future:** must has no past form; use had to / will have to. Should keeps the same form.

🟢 Examples

1. Fill in with must, mustn't or don't have to: "Campers ___ leave plastic in the forest." **Answer:** mustn't. **Explanation:** it is forbidden, so prohibition is needed, not absence of obligation.
2. "Tomorrow is a holiday, so the pupils ___ go to school." **Answer:** don't have to. **Explanation:** going is not necessary; it is not forbidden.
3. Give advice to a friend who wastes water. **Answer:** You should take shorter showers and you shouldn't leave the tap running. **Explanation:** advice uses should / shouldn't, not must.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Treating **mustn't** and **don't have to** as the same; the first forbids, the second only removes the obligation.
- Adding "to" after must or should: "must to go", "should to recycle".
- Writing "he must goes" or "she have to"; the base verb follows a modal, and have to agrees with the subject.
- Using must for the past ("Yesterday I must…") instead of had to.

🟡 Quick review

- must / have to = obligation; should = advice.
- mustn't = forbidden; don't have to = not necessary.
- Modal + base verb, no "to", no -s.
- Past of must = had to.
- Rules of a park: must / mustn't; tips to a friend: should / shouldn't.

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